



## **The Oberwald Mystery** Il mistero di Oberwald

Director: Michelangelo Antonioni

Presented by/Production Company: RAI

Production Company: Polytel International

Producers: Sergio Benvenuti,

Alessandro von Normann, Giancarlo Bernardoni

Production Supervisors: Bruno Cavagna,

Vittorio Petri

Technical Co-ordinator: Carlo Torelli

Production Assistant: Enrico Bellani

Assistant Director: Wanda Lazzarino

Adapted for the screen by:

Michelangelo Antonioni, Tonino Guerra

Based on the play by: Jean Cocteau

Director of Photography: Luciano Tovoli

Camera Control: Claudio Mornata

Colour and Electronic Effects Adviser:

Franco De Leonardis

Camera Operators: Gianni Bonaldi,

An nibale Menin, Tarcisio Cattaneo

Key Grip: Mario Moreschini

Chief Electrician: Giordano Orsini Rolando

Special Effects: Armando Grilli, Vito Rossi

Graphic Artists: Scenografia Oggi, Silvano Spaccesi

Electronic Editing: Michelangelo Antonioni,

Francesco Grandoni

Set Designer: Mischa Scandella

Collaborators (Set Design):

Athos Mastrogirolamo, Angelo Santucci

Set Decorator: Stefani Conti

Assistant Set Decorator: Saverio Mainieri

Propmen: Gianni Comite, Bruno Vandilli

Costume Designer: Vittoria Guaita

Collaborator (Costumes): Matteo Arpone

Make-up: Roberto Del Brocco, Miranda Liviero

Hairdressers: Grazia De Rossi, Angelo Aprile

Collaborator (Music): Guido Turchi

Audio Technician: Gianfranco Desideri

Videomagnetic Sound Recording: Claudio Grandini

Soundtrack: Sandro Peticca, Fiorenza Muller

Boom Operator: Mario Pessina

Sound Re-recording: Fausto Ancillai

Collaborator (Sound Effects): Alvaro Gramigna

Cast:

Monica Vitti (*the queen*)

Paolo Bonacelli (*Count di Foehn*)

Franco Branciaroli (*Sebastian*)

Luigi Diberti (*Felix, Duke of Willenstein*)

Elisabetta Pozzi (*Edith de Berg*)

Amad Saha Alan (*Tony*)

Silvano Tranquilli \*

Italy-Germany 1980

129 mins

Digital

\* Uncredited

Courtesy of Cinecittà

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## **Monica Vitti: Creative Force**

# **The Oberwald Mystery**

## **Monica Vitti on 'The Oberwald Mystery'**

*Naturally, this further professional encounter with Antonioni was not by chance...*

Of course not. Michelangelo and I had been talking for years about the possibility of making another film together. Probably because our friendship, our feeling good together, never did come to an end during this time. What was a chance, was the choice of making Jean Cocteau's *The Two-Headed Eagle* (*L'Aigle à deux têtes*). At the beginning, we had thought of *The Human Voice* (*La voce umana*), but there was the precedent of Anna Magnani and Roberto Rossellini, and to confront ourselves with them seemed to us in bad taste. Thus we thought of Cocteau's *Bell'indifferente* (*Le bel indifférent*), with the ending turned upside down. Finally, our choice was for *The Two-Headed Eagle*.

*And what was it that made you decide?*

The idea was Michelangelo's. He liked the situation behind what actually happens: the queen, a symbol of power who is waiting only for the moment to die, and the young man, the opposition that feels it must intervene and assassinate power. But later on we saw the film Cocteau himself made of it, with Jean Marais and Edwige Feuillère, and we felt most uncomfortable: it was so rhetorical ... Maybe wanting to make something completely different out of it was what actually convinced us finally: the desire to make a melodrama with sobriety.

*Antonioni was interested in the coinciding paths of destinies which at times occurs between the aims of power and counter-power. What was it that interested you?*

I liked the queen. No, not the queen, the woman who had firmly decided to die, who was only awaiting the right moment to no longer exist and instead, at a certain point, contradicts herself: she wants to live, to love, to start again. The imponderables of life, the right to change one's mind, have always fascinated me. I like to suppose that the characters take their very author by the hand and decide, become autonomous, stronger than the very ideological framework that supports them.

*A moment ago, you switched from the term 'queen' to the more common word 'woman'...*

Yes, because when one thinks of a queen, when one has to act the character of a queen, one inevitably ends up by giving her the tones, the movements, the looks of conventionality. Therefore false. I did not want to put a queen onto the screen, but a woman. I am interested in people understanding the stories I am telling, and I feel that in order to be understood one must be sincere. Sincerity is my goal. Thinking and doing the things that people think and do, transforming them, personalising them, re-inventing them. Take costumes, for instance: when an actor is in a period costume, he (or she) often ends up by being conditioned by it, by moving within it as in a marriage suit (or dress). I, on the other hand, tried to feel as if I were wearing one of my everyday dresses when I was wearing the theatre costumes. I would have liked to be able to kick

## Monica Vitti: Creative Force

### **Clever Girls** Le dritte

Sat 1 Aug 14:50; Mon 10 Aug 20:40 (+ intro by writer Richard Dyer)

### **Red Desert** Il deserto rosso

Sun 2 Aug 12:10; Sat 8 Aug 14:30;  
Sun 16 Aug 15:00; Mon 24 Aug 20:40

### **L'eclisse** The Eclipse

Sun 2 Aug 18:10; Sun 9 Aug 15:00 (+ intro by season curator Catherine O'Rawe);

Thu 13 Aug 20:30

### **Modesty Blaise**

Mon 3 Aug 18:00; Sat 22 Aug 14:50

### **Monica Vitti Season Introduction**

Thu 6 Aug 18:10

### **L'avventura** The Adventure

Thu 6 Aug 20:20; Thu 20 Aug 18:00

### **I Married You for Fun** Ti ho sposato per allegria

Sat 8 Aug 12:00; Wed 12 Aug 20:30 (+ intro by writer and researcher Olga Campofreda)

### **Teresa the Thief** Teresa la ladra

Sat 8 Aug 18:00; Tue 18 Aug 20:35

### **La notte** The Night

Sat 8 Aug 20:30; Wed 26 Aug 18:10  
(+ pre-recorded intro by Joanna Biggs)

### **Stardust** Polvere di stelle

Sun 9 Aug 17:50 (+ intro by season curator Catherine O'Rawe); Tue 18 Aug 18:00

### **Tosca** La Tosca

Tue 11 Aug 18:10; Sat 29 Aug 12:20

### **The Oberwald Mystery** Il mistero di Oberwald

Fri 14 Aug 18:10; Sat 29 Aug 18:00

### **The Girl with a Pistol** La ragazza con la pistola

Wed 19 Aug 18:10; Sat 29 Aug 20:55

### **I Know That You Know That I Know**

Io so che tu sai che io so

Thu 20 Aug 20:45; Mon 31 Aug 12:00

### **Secret Scandal** Scandalo segreto

Mon 24 Aug 18:30; Thu 27 Aug 20:45

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away, as Bette Davis did in her film on Queen Elizabeth. This is why that of the two costumes I wear in this film, the one in which I felt most at ease is the authentic period one. Its smell, the feeling of the past in it, memories, all helped me in my search for authenticity.

*Antonioni is a 'dry' or a 'lean' director, in the sense that he communicates with looks, with colours, with silence rather than with words. Jean Cocteau is used mainly to words: to great, sweeping passions, ample gestures...*

Quite, and the biggest job was to have to do but little on stage. Personally, I am (unfortunately) of a passionate temperament. Hot reactions was what first came to my mind, and it was beautiful to have them and have to hold them in. They were useful, but were not to be seen outside. I had to 'brake' myself, put the brakes on. But that is what acting is all about anyway: taking away, and not adding. A play of hands, looks, tones, half-smiles, half-sadness. Sergio Tofano, one of my teachers at the Academy, used to often repeat Diderot's position on acting, that one should act passion without feeling it. I feel rather that one should feel emotions without ever failing to check them, and place between year own self and the character you are living, a critical diaphragm which prevents you from letting yourself completely go with regard to the stage pretence. Basically, a matter of self-respect.

*And in order to reach this sort of double-self state, an actor uses professionalism?*

Professionalism, maybe, and up to a certain point. But not technique. Technique is not sufficient for me: it can help me raise or lower the tone, open or close a vowel when speaking, move or stop a muscle. It does not help me, however, create a character.

*Strange that a person whose profession has been acting for so many years should not manage to find technique a valid support for acting well...*

Acting is not a technique, it's a state of mind. And, what's more, a fragile state of mind, that can easily be broken from one moment to the next. Maybe, for actors who work mainly on the stage, technique can be helpful because the spectator, in a theatre, sees the actor from afar, small, distant. And sometimes you can get away with cheating. But for these who, as I, work mainly in films, you get used to the camera X-raying you: it frames your eyes right down to the depths, and if at the bottom of your eyes there is no emotion, that's the end. The pretending game ends right there. Maybe that is why I am keener on doing comic rather than dramatic parts.

*Are you saying that this film, The Oberwald Mystery, was difficult for you to act?*

The most difficult part of all for me was the character in *Red Desert*, because I was *deserto rosso*: my anxiety, my wanderings, my illusions. And nothing is more painful for me than being myself. Because this means that night and day, on stage and in life, I am obliged to remain anchored to my problems, without ever being able to eliminate them for an instant ... Who knows, maybe it was a matter of personal survival that pushed me on towards comedy.

Interview by Simonetta Robiony